

VIKINGS NFL FLAG RULES REVIEW

Game Format

- Games start with a coin toss; teams switch sides at half.
- Each drive starts at the Offensive team's own 5-yard line.
- Four downs to reach midfield 1st Down line: "1st Down, 2nd Down, 3rd Down, 4th Down"
- "Punt or Go For It" decision must be made on 4th down.
- Punt = Change of possession, ball is brought to opposite 5 yd. line
- Go For It = Offense must cross midfield to gain 1st down
- If they fail to cross midfield, other team's ball where the 4th down play ended
- After the Offense crosses midfield 1st Down line, they have 3 downs to score from there: "Three downs to score, Two downs to score, Last Down" (Officials should use this terminology to avoid confusion with coaches)
- If the Offense fails to score in 3 downs, it is a turnover on downs, possession changes, and the ball is placed on the other team's 5 yd line.

Gameplay Basics

- 5 players per team on the field. If a team arrives with 3 or fewer players or fails to arrive 15 minutes after their scheduled game time, a 35-0 forfeit will be recorded.
- Offense must have a Center snap the ball to the QB from the ground. Center may side snap or snap between the legs.
- QB can NEVER run. Ball must be advanced via backfield handoff/toss/lateral or forward pass across the line of scrimmage.
- The QB is defined as the player who directly receives the snap
- One forward pass allowed per play, forward pass must be thrown from behind the line of scrimmage and the ball must be caught beyond the line of scrimmage.
- Handoffs, tosses, and laterals are only allowed behind the line of scrimmage.
- Offense may choose to run or pass on any play, unless they are in a "No Run" zone: 5 yds before 1st Down, 5 yds before Goal Line. (Does not apply to 1st-2nd grade division, see below)
- No blocking, screening, hurdling, or flag guarding allowed.
- Flag belts must be worn on hips and unobstructed; jerseys must be tucked inside flag belt.

Timing

- Games: Two 24-minute halves (continuous clock).
- Offense has a 40 second play clock in-between plays
- Each team has one timeout per half; timeouts are 60-seconds long

Scoring

- Touchdown = 6 points
- Extra Points: 1 (from 5-yard line, pass only) or 2 (from 10-yard line, run/pass).
- Interceptions returned for TD = 6 points (or 2 points on conversions)

- Safety = 2 points and possession on opposite 5 yd. line
- A forfeit is recorded when one team takes a 35+ point lead. Teams may agree to continue playing, but officials will not continue to keep score.

Dead Ball Situations

- Flag pulled, fumbled ball, knee/arm down, dropped flag, incomplete pass, expiration of 7-second pass clock = play ends.

Officials Positioning

- 2 Officials: One on line of scrimmage on one sideline, one at 7 yd. rush line on the opposite sideline (1st-2nd grade games: Both officials can be on line of scrimmage, because there is no rushing)

RULES MODIFICATIONS BY GRADE DIVISION

1st-2nd Grade Division

- Defense CANNOT rush the QB
- "No Run" zones are eliminated - teams can run the ball anywhere on the field
- Defense must align 5 yds off the line of scrimmage.
- If the line of scrimmage is inside the 5 yd line, that distance is reduced to 3 yds.
- Snaps that hit the ground are ruled as "Do Overs" and NOT Loss of Down
- (Officials may play it by ear: If the QB immediately picks up the ball, Officials can let it play by saying "Play on". If the snap is wild and goes over the QB's head and/or rolls away from the QB, then the play should be blown dead and replay the down)
- One coach per team allowed on the field at all times
- 1st-2nd grade division uses "Pee Wee" (Blue) NFL FLAG footballs

3rd-4th, 5th-6th, and 7th-8th Grade Divisions

- Defense CAN rush the QB
- Up to 2 defenders may rush; must be aligned at least 7 yds. beyond the LOS at the snap and may rush as soon as the ball is snapped
- Rusher(s) must identify themselves pre-snap by aligning behind the 7 yd. rush line and raising their hand. A maximum of 2 defenders may raise their hand. Only players who raise their hand may rush. Players who raise their hand are NOT obligated to rush, but if they do, they must rush immediately after the snap. No delayed rushes allowed.
- "No Run" zones are in play - 5 yards before the midfield 1st Down and 5 yards before the Goal Line, the Offense may not handoff/toss/lateral in the backfield. Offense must complete a forward pass across the LOS to advance the ball.
- Snaps that hit the ground are ruled as a dead ball and Loss of Down
- One coach per team allowed on the field in-between plays, but must exit the field before the snap
- 3rd-4th grade uses "Pee Wee" (Blue) NFL FLAG footballs
- 5th-6th and 7th-8th grade divisions use "Junior" (Brown) NFL FLAG footballs

OVERTIME RULES

- If the score is tied at the end of regulation, an Overtime period will be played
- Referees will determine which end of the field OT will be played
- No Timeouts in OT. There is no game clock, but 40 second play clock still applies.

1st OT:

- Coin Toss
- Team that wins the coin toss can choose to play Offense or Defense first
- Team on Offense first gets 1 play and can choose to:
 - Go for 1-point conversion - from the 5 yd line, pass only
 - Go for 2-point conversion - from the 10 yd line, run or pass
- Team on Offense 2nd then gets 1 play and can choose to go for 1-point or 2-point conversion, to try to tie or win the game
- If Defense returns an Interception for a TD, game is over - team on Defense wins

2nd OT:

- If teams are still tied after 1st OT:
- Team that lost the 1st OT coin toss chooses Offense or Defense first
- Both teams get 1 play and must go for 2-point conversion - from the 10 yd line, run or pass
- If Defense returns an Interception for a TD - game is over - team on Defense wins

3rd OT:

- If teams are still tied after 2nd OT:
- Team that won the 1st OT coin toss chooses Offense or Defense first
- Ball is placed on the 5 yd line with the Offense now facing away from the endzone, going out towards the field
- Both teams will run 1 play - run or pass
- The team that gains the most yards on their 1 play wins
- Run plays resulting in a defender pulling a flag behind the line of scrimmage count as negative yardage
- Sacks via a defensive rusher pulling a flag behind the line of scrimmage count as negative yardage
- Sacks via the Official's 7-second pass clock expiring count as 0 yards
- If both teams throw an incomplete pass, move to a 4th OT, repeating this 3rd OT process
- If the Officials determine the yardage is too close to call, move to a 4th OT, repeating this 3rd OT process
- Both teams must run at least 1 Offensive play in 3rd OT UNLESS:
 - A pass is Intercepted on the first play, the game is over - team on Defense wins (DOES NOT NEED TO BE RETURNED FOR A TD)
 - A Safety is scored by the Defense on the first play, the game is over - team on Defense wins

PENALTIES

ii. Defensive spot fouls

Defensive pass interference	Automatic first down
Holding/Illegal Contact	+5 yards and automatic first down
Stripping	+5 yards and automatic first down

iii. Offensive spot fouls

Screening or blocking	-5 yards and loss of down
Charging	-5 yards and loss of down
Flag guarding	-5 yards and loss of down
Holding/Illegal Contact	-5 yards and loss of down

iv. Defensive penalties

Defensive unnecessary roughness	+10 yards and automatic first down
Defensive unsportsmanlike conduct	+10 yards and automatic first down
Offside / illegal substitution	+5 yards from line of scrimmage and automatic first down
Illegal rush (Starting rush from inside 7-yard marker)	+5 yards from line of scrimmage and automatic first down
Illegal flag pull (Before the receiver has the ball)	+5 yards from line of scrimmage and automatic first down
Roughing the passer	+5 yards from line of scrimmage and automatic first down
Taunting	+10 yards from line of scrimmage and automatic first down

v. Offensive penalties

Offensive unnecessary roughness	-10 yards and loss of down
Offensive unsportsmanlike conduct	-10 yards and loss of down
Offside / false start / illegal substitution	-5 yards from line of scrimmage and loss of down
Illegal forward pass (Any pass received or lands behind the line of scrimmage or throwing a pass after crossing the line of scrimmage)	-5 yards from line of scrimmage and loss of down
Offensive pass interference	-5 yards from line of scrimmage and loss of down
Illegal motion (More than one person moving)	-5 yards from line of scrimmage and loss of down
Delay of game	-5 yards from line of scrimmage and loss of down
Impeding the rusher	-5 yards from line of scrimmage and loss of down
Illegal Procedure	-5 yards from line of scrimmage and loss of down
Taunting	-10 yards from line of scrimmage and loss of down